

KEY EVENTS

19TH CENTURY

■ **1830–48** France invades Algeria, but Abd el-Kadir leads resistance to the French occupation of the territory until forced to surrender in 1848.

■ **1845–72** Maori opposition to the British colonization of New Zealand is overcome in a series of hard-fought wars.

■ **1857–58** A rebellion against British rule in India is put down by armed force.

■ **1860** A combined Anglo-French army invades China and occupies Beijing, looting and burning Chinese imperial palaces.

■ **1868** In Japan, the Tokugawa Shogunate ends and the period of the Meiji Restoration begins, during which time Japan modernizes its armed forces and society.

■ **1876–77** In the Black Hills War, Sioux warriors led by Crazy Horse mount the last serious resistance to the westward expansion of the United States.

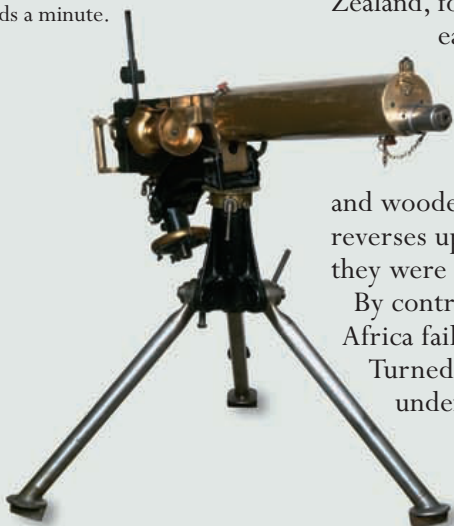
■ **1879** At Rorke's Drift, 150 British soldiers armed chiefly with Martini-Henry rifles successfully resist repeated attacks by 4,000 Zulu warriors.

■ **1898** An Anglo-Egyptian army defeats the Sudanese Mahdists at Omdurman (see pp.250–51). The Sudanese are cut down by rapid-fire rifles and Maxim guns.

■ **1900** In the Boer War, Boer militia armed with the latest German weapons inflict a notable defeat on the British Army at Spion Kop.

▼ MAXIM GUN

Invented in 1884 by Sir Hiram Maxim, the recoil-operated Maxim gun was the first fully automatic weapon, firing for as long as the trigger was held down. Its maximum rate of fire was 500 rounds a minute.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

THE WARS OF EMPIRES

In the 19th century, a gulf opened up between the military technology of Europe and North America, and the rest of the world. Pre-industrial societies, such as China, Japan, and Africa, could not withstand the firepower of imperial armies.

The armies of the world's great powers underwent a technological revolution between 1815 and 1914, progressing from flintlock muskets to repeater rifles firing metal cartridges, and from smoothbore muzzle-loading cannon to rifled guns firing high-explosive shells. Widely adopted in the 1890s, the Maxim gun – the first self-powered machine-gun – became a symbol of technological progress and the alleged superiority of European civilization. Steamships projected this increased firepower worldwide in campaigns waged on every continent.

Some wars of the imperialist era were between powers that had fallen behind in the race for military modernization. The defeat of China by European forces, in the Opium Wars of 1839–42 and 1856–60, demonstrated how a country long at the forefront of technological innovation and military organization could suddenly find itself defenceless at a time of rapid change. Both China and Japan attempted to adopt the technology of the West, but China's defeat by Japan in the war of 1894–95, and its invasion by European powers in response to the Boxer rebellion of 1900, showed that the Chinese had failed. Japan, in contrast, established itself as the sole Asian modern military power after its victory over Russia in 1904–05 (see pp.264–65), in which it deployed the latest military technology, from steel battleships and torpedo boats to machine-guns, rifled artillery, and field telephones.

BATTLES WITH TRIBES

Other conflicts of the era led the armies of Europe and North America into combat with indigenous tribal societies. These tribal groups were formidable in their varied traditional styles of warfare, and often succeeded in integrating modern firearms into their fighting techniques. The Maori of New Zealand, for example, acquired muskets from the early 1800s, and used them in a series of wars – first against one another, and then against European settlers backed by the British Army. Firing rifled muskets from elaborate defensive earthworks and wooden palisades, the Maori inflicted notable reverses upon the British in the 1860s, although they were eventually defeated.

By contrast, however, the Zulu of southern Africa failed to make effective use of firearms.

Turned into an impressive military machine under the leadership of Shaka (1816–28),

they had achieved regional dominance by fighting aggressive wars against neighbouring peoples with stabbing spears and cowhide shields. They mostly relied on the same equipment against an invading British Army in 1879, using rifles only for a scattered volley, before charging to engage at close quarters. Despite a victory at Isandlwana, the Zulu were soon forced to concede defeat due to casualties inflicted by British bullets and bayonets.

FRONTIER BATTLES

Expanding their territory westwards, the US fought Plains Indian tribes such as the Sioux, Cheyenne, and Arapaho from the 1860s to the 1880s. The Plains Indians used modern technology – firearms, including repeater rifles, and steel knives – but they fought best with traditional bows and spears.

